

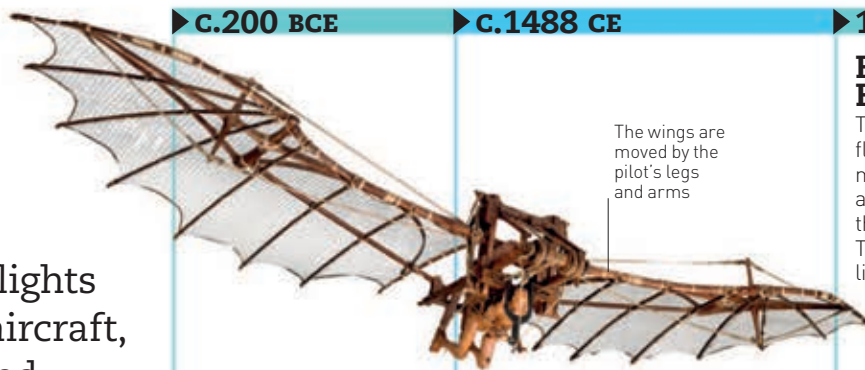
The story of flight

From the first balloon and glider flights to the launch of a solar-powered aircraft, people have always been fascinated by the idea of flying. The invention of aircraft that can carry people was one of the 20th century's great triumphs, and helped to shape the modern world.

► C.200 BCE

► C.1488 CE

► 1783



The wings are moved by the pilot's legs and arms

ORNITHOPTER

KONGMING LANTERN

The Chinese-invented sky lantern (a hot-air balloon made from paper) is named the Kongming lantern. It is used for signalling between military troops.

LEONARDO DA VINCI

An ornithopter – a wing-flapping aircraft – is designed by Leonardo da Vinci. He also sketches flying machines such as helicopters and parachutes (although he does not build them), and studies airflows and streamlined shapes.

FIRST MANNED FLIGHT

The first recorded manned flight – lasting about 25 minutes – takes place in a hot-air balloon built by the Montgolfier brothers. The balloon is made of linen lined with paper.



MONTGOLFIER BROTHERS' HOT-AIR BALLOON

◀ 1947

◀ 1944

◀ 1939

◀ 1932

FIRST SUPERSONIC FLIGHT

US Air Force captain Charles "Chuck" Yeager becomes the first pilot to travel faster than the speed of sound in the Bell X-1. This rocket-powered aircraft does not take off from the ground but is launched from the belly of a Boeing B-29 at an altitude of 7000 m (23,000 ft).



GLOSTER METEOR F MK8

FIRST COMBAT JET

In July the British Gloster Meteor Mk1 becomes the world's first operational jet fighter. It is followed closely by Nazi Germany's Messerschmitt Me262s, which begin attacking American bombers in October the same year.

FIRST HELICOPTER FLIGHT

Russian-born Igor Sikorsky makes the first flight in his VS-300 helicopter, establishing the single main rotor and smaller tail rotor layout that is now so familiar.

SIKORSKY'S LATER R-4 HELICOPTERS WERE USED IN WORLD WAR II

AMELIA EARHART

The first woman to fly solo across the Atlantic, Amelia Earhart faces strong winds and mechanical problems on her 15-hour journey from Newfoundland to Ireland. The flight is made in a bright red Lockheed Vega 5B.



AMELIA EARHART

► 1952

► 1967

► 1969

► 1976



DE HAVILLAND DH106 COMET 4C

FIRST JETLINER

The de Havilland Comet 1, the world's first ever jetliner, enters service. There are 36 passengers on the maiden flight between London and Johannesburg, South Africa. The journey, including stops, takes 23 hours, 38 minutes, and the return fare costs £315.



X-15

FASTEST MANNED AIRCRAFT

An experimental rocket-powered aircraft, the X-15, achieves 7273 km/h (4520 mph) – nearly seven times the speed of sound. This remains the record for a manned aircraft.

FIRST SUPERSONIC AIRLINER

Concorde, the world's first supersonic airliner, makes its maiden flight. The jet will enter service in 1976, with a typical London-to-New-York journey taking just under three and a half hours. However, Concorde's huge operating costs will make the price of tickets very expensive.

CONCORDE

FASTEST JET AIRCRAFT

The Lockheed SR-71 Blackbird sets the official air speed record for a manned jet aircraft with a speed of 3530 km/h (2193 mph).

SR-71 BLACKBIRD

